

Unless you're writing “throwaway” code that you don't intend to maintain after you run the program once, you should put some thought into selecting good names in your program. If you simply use `a`, `b`, and `c` for variable names, your future self will expend unnecessary effort to remember what these variables were initially used for.

Names are a subjective choice that you must make. An automated formatting tool, such as Black, described in Chapter 3, can't decide what you should name your variables. This chapter provides you with some guidelines to help you choose suitable names and avoid poor names. As always, these guidelines aren't written in stone: use your judgment to decide when to apply them to your code.

METASYNTACTIC VARIABLES

We commonly use a *metasyntactic variable* in tutorials or code snippets when we need a generic variable name. In Python, we often name variables `spam`, `eggs`, `bacon`, and `ham` in code examples where the variable name isn't important. That's why this book uses these names in code examples; they aren't meant for you to use them in real-world programs. These names come from Monty Python's “Spam” sketch ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Spam_\(Monty_Python\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Spam_(Monty_Python))). The names `foo` and `bar` are also common for metasyntactic variables. These are derived from FUBAR, the World War II era US Army slang acronym that indicates a situation is “[messed] up beyond all recognition.”

Casing Styles

Because Python identifiers are case sensitive and cannot contain whitespace, programmers use several styles for identifiers that include multiple words:

`snake_case` separates words with an underscore, which looks like a flat snake in between each word. This case often implies that all letters are lowercase, although constants are often written in `UPPER_SNAKE_CASE`.

`camelCase` separates words by capitalizing the start of each word after the first. This case often implies the first word begins with a lowercase letter. The uppercase letters look like a camel's humps.